Now the *Aleksandrovsk* was supposed to take the warheads for both the R-12 and R-14 missiles back to the USSR. The most dangerous ship in the world was about to become even more dangerous. They loaded the nuclear warheads for R-12 Desna missiles into its hold on the night of November 4 at Isabela de Sagua. Next day the *Aleksandrovsk* sailed to Mariel, where it joined the dry cargo ship *Divnogorsk*, the first vessel to be loaded with missiles for return to the USSR. A brand-new ship built in Poland in 1960, the *Divnogorsk* had arrived in Mariel on October 23, beating the blockade by a few hours. Statsenko's men began loading the *Divnogorsk* on November 2, taking on board four R-12 missiles and 310 officers and men. Since it was the first ship ready for departure, it was chosen as an escort for the *Aleksandrovsk* with its nuclear cargo.[22]

The *Divnogorsk* and the *Aleksandrovsk* began their voyage home on November 6, with the former trailing the latter at a distance of three to five miles and maintaining radio contact. In case of emergency the two ships were supposed to communicate with each other by means of light signals. Major Protasov, the KGB officer assigned to the *Divnogorsk*, ordered his agents to keep the communications with the *Aleksandrovsk* under surveillance. They were also ordered to be on the lookout for possible spies and saboteurs. Their own people were under suspicion: one of the soldiers who had arrived in Cuba in October on the *Divnogorsk* had been overheard asking questions about transportation between Cuba and the United States —a clear sign in the eyes of Major Protasov that there was a defector in the making. No one knew what to expect of the new military contingent now on its way back from Cuba.[23]

The two ships traveled together until November 10, before reaching the thirtieth meridian, and then parted ways, the *Aleksandrovsk* heading for the Baltic Sea, while the *Divnogorsk*, whose home port was Odesa, made its way to the Black Sea. Major Protasov wrote in his report that American airplanes followed the two ships throughout their joint voyage. Overflights during the first day of sailing were especially intensive: the KGB officer referred to them as psychological attacks. "Making shaving flights, disregarding all rules, without signal lights, they circled the ships [even] in bad weather or fog," wrote Protasov. Some of the planes flew ten to fifteen meters above the surface of the water—Protasov believed that they were